

Djokovic recovers from a tough start to extend Beijing winning run

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Novak Djokovic kept his **unbeaten** record in Beijing after a demanding **comeback** against China's Bu Yunchaokete. The six-time champion recovered from losing the opening set to win 4-6, 7-6 (7-2), 6-2 and reach the China Open's third round.

The result took Djokovic's record in Beijing to 31 matches without a defeat. This victory required two hours and 52 minutes of effort, and Bu made the Serbian player work for it.

During the second set, Djokovic lost an advantage he had gained by winning one of Bu's service games. He needed a medical timeout and received a **time violation** while trying to regain his breath between points. A **time violation** means a player has taken longer than the rules allow before play continues.

The 39-year-old consulted the trainer, then took control of the tie-break, winning it 7-2. A tie-break is a special scoring game used to settle a close set. Djokovic found his rhythm in the deciding set, won four games in **succession** and ended the match with a backhand winner.

In the women's event, Aryna Sabalenka began her campaign by beating Mexico's Renata Zarazua 6-1, 6-3. She hit 11 aces and faced no **break points**, meaning Zarazua never reached a point that could win a game on Sabalenka's serve.

It was Sabalenka's first match since losing her number one ranking and US Open title to Elena Rybakina in September. Her latest tournament title came in Miami in March.

Sabalenka explained that demanding more from herself can drive her forward, but can also drain her energy. She said she was trying to be less **self-critical**. She was due to face Czech player Nikola Bartunkova next, while Djokovic's next opponent would be Alexander Zverev or Shang Juncheng.

Word Treasure

unbeaten -- Having played without losing.

comeback -- A recovery after falling behind.

time violation -- Taking longer than the rules allow before play continues.

break points -- Points that could let a player win a game on an opponent's serve.

succession -- One after another, in a row.

self-critical -- Quick to judge your own performance harshly.

Background you need

A tie-break is a special scoring game used to settle a close set.

A break point gives the player receiving serve a chance to win that game.

Break it down

Opens with Djokovic's comeback, score and advancement.

Describes his unbeaten record and the match's length.

Explains the second-set difficulties and tie-break.

Describes his finish in the deciding set.

Reports Sabalenka's result, recent title history and comments.

Ends with the players' possible or scheduled next opponents.

Why it matters

The match extended Djokovic's unbeaten Beijing record and sent him into the third round. Sabalenka's victory also provided a chance for her to explain the pressures she puts on herself.

Test what you remember

1. What did Djokovic's win take his Beijing record to?

- ☐ (A) 31 matches without a defeat
- ☐ (B) 51 matches without a defeat
- ☐ (C) 21 matches without a defeat
- ☐ (D) 41 matches without a defeat

2. What advantage did Djokovic lose during the second set?

- ☐ (A) The lead from winning the deciding set
- ☐ (B) The lead from winning Bu's service game
- ☐ (C) The lead from winning the opening set
- ☐ (D) The lead from winning the second set

3. What does a time violation mean?

- ☐ (A) A player serves from the wrong side.
- ☐ (B) A player requests a new opponent.
- ☐ (C) A player changes ends too often.
- ☐ (D) A player takes longer than allowed.

4. How did Djokovic finish the match?

- ☐ (A) With a forehand winner
- ☐ (B) With a winning volley
- ☐ (C) With a backhand winner
- ☐ (D) With an untouched serve

5. What does Sabalenka facing no break points mean?

- ☐ (A) Zarazua never reached a point that could win her own service game.
- ☐ (B) Sabalenka never reached a point that could win her own service game.
- ☐ (C) Sabalenka never reached a point that could win Zarazua's service game.
- ☐ (D) Zarazua never reached a point that could win Sabalenka's service game.

6. How did Sabalenka describe demanding more from herself?

- ☐ (A) It keeps her energy from changing.
- ☐ (B) It makes every match feel easier.
- ☐ (C) It helps her choose her opponents.
- ☐ (D) It motivates her but can drain her.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She said demanding more from herself can motivate her but can also drain her energy. She is trying to be less self-critical.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):